Youthwashing as Political Performance in the Digital Age: Discursive Construction on X (Twitter), Instagram, and Facebook During Nigeria's 2026-2027 Electioneering

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Abstract

During the second phase of INEC's 2026 Continuous Voter Registration (CVR), 9,324,349 young Nigerians were newly registered. This period in the Fourth Republic marks an unprecedented democratic awakening, reminiscent of the #EndSARS protests and the 2023 Obidient Movement. While political elites acknowledge the electoral significance of youth demographics, much of their campaign messaging targets them. This study explored 'youthwashing' as a form of theatrical political rhetoric on X (formerly Twitter), Instagram, and Facebook between 19 August and 30 October 2026, during Nigeria's 2027 election campaign preparations. Using multimodal discourse analysis and theories of mediated authenticity and performativity, it analysed how politicians and influencers portray "youth" as an electoral asset while marginalising them in policy engagement. A purposive sample of 60 public posts across Facebook, X, and Instagram was selected based on youth-oriented hashtags, visuals, and captions. The findings were examined against indicators such as hidden sponsorship, tokenistic youth imagery, hedged policy claims, and aestheticised politics, collectively revealing political elites' youthwashing. The study argued that these tactics foster an illusion of youth inclusion without genuine representation or accountability, influencing perceived legitimacy and potentially discouraging meaningful youth participation. Recommendations on campaign regulation, disclosure standards, youth, and media literacy will shape future electoral discourse in Nigeria.

Keywords: Digital Age, Electioneering, Facebook, Instagram, Nigeria, X, Youthwashing, Youth Agency, 2027 elections

Introduction

One enduring phenomenon shaping politics, polity, and policy is the internet's democratisation and its redefinition of political life, especially electioneering. The mass exodus of voters to social media platforms has reshaped political communication, including how it is framed and targeted. As digital natives grow, political elites match them with a vast supply of niche messages that mirror and resonate with them. This paradigm shift emboldens digital activism, social reengineering, and political manoeuvring. It is an unprecedented development for both encoders and decoders of digital semiotics. Incidentally, the forthcoming 2026-2027 Nigerian elections are set against a political climate in which youth have increasingly gained prominence in the country's democratic politics. One major sign of this trend was observed during the second round of the Continuous Voter Registration (CVR). According to INEC statistics, 9,324,349 young Nigerians were newly registered during the 2026 exercise (Akinwale, 2026). This increased visibility makes it possible to consider how political actors communicate with youth before elections.

Mustapha and Omar (2020) argued that Nigerian youths engaged in substantial online political activity during the 2019 elections and that social media use remained important even when other forms of civic and political engagement were controlled for the public good or for ulterior motives. Obisesan (2022) found that social media helped Nigerian youths build political agency, engage in debate, and develop socio-political networks

during the 2019 elections. These studies collectively established that young Nigerians are both consumers and producers of political communication. This was evident during the youth-led #EndSARS protests against incessant police brutality in October 2020. The youths fiercely deployed social media such as Twitter (now X), Facebook, Instagram, WhatsApp, and others to inform, document abuses, organise protests, and lobby for reforms. The protests highlighted the role that digital platforms might play in youth political participation and collective action (Adegbola et al., 2022; Uwalaka, 2022).

According to Dambo et al. (2022), Chiluwa (2023), and Awopetu and Chiluwa (2023), social media gave Nigerian youths opportunities to express grievances collectively and organise protests, while also revealing the systemic constraints facing digitally mediated activism. The political forces of #EndSARS also converged with the 2023 political environment, especially the rise of the Obidient movement. This indicates that young people's political activism in Nigeria increasingly occurs through digitally mediated collective identity and communication. As Ezeigbo (2025) demonstrates in his analysis of the 2023 elections, youths used social media for political advocacy, communication, and political activities.

However, this trend creates a major paradox. As young Nigerians' electoral importance grows, political elites have an incentive to recognise, respond to, and connect with youth. Meanwhile, youth are excluded from candidate selection, policy creation, political decision-making, and leadership. This distinction between visibility and agency lies at the heart of contemporary political communication aimed at youth. Ezeigbo (2025) notes that with the youth's high level of social media engagement during the 2023 elections, young Nigerians' participation has increased; however, this does not mean political institutions have given young people equal influence.

In this context, youthwashing serves as the organising framework for the current research. Viterbo (2025) defined youthwashing as a cynical practice that exploits young people without necessarily addressing their problems or engaging them. This definition helps us develop a conceptual approach to studying situations where the symbolism of youth inclusion does not align with youth activism. Accordingly, the current study adopts youthwashing as a relevant concept for analysing youth-oriented political communication in Nigeria, treating it as an analytical lens observable in practices such as tokenistic youth imagery, behind-the-scenes sponsorship, policy hedging, and aesthetic politics.

Research Questions

The research questions that guide the study are as follows:

1. How is youth participation discursively constructed on X, Instagram, and Facebook during Nigeria's 2026-2027 electioneering?

2. In what ways are youth represented through textual, visual, and audiovisual features in selected political posts on X, Instagram, and Facebook?

3. In what ways can youthwashing be observed through sponsorship, tokenism, hedging in policy discourse, and the aesthetics of politics?

4. How do the constructions and manifestations of youthwashing vary across X, Instagram, and Facebook during Nigeria's 2026-2027 electioneering?

Literature Review

This study reviews existing literature on social media, youth as a communication agency, and media advocacy as an intervention tool for the silenced voices. The review covers relevant concepts, theories, and empirical studies to help define the existing knowledge base and to lay the groundwork for the present study.

Youthwashing as Political Performance

According to Viterbo (2025), youthwashing is the self-centred appropriation of youth that fails to adequately address their interests. Viterbo shows how organisations may invoke youth participation while retaining considerable discretion over whose voices they listen to and how they define participation. Youthwashing becomes relevant to political communication in electoral competition, and when politicians try to show their connection to young voters. The "washing" family of concepts highlights situations in which institutions, companies, or politicians strategically associate themselves with socially valuable causes or identities through communication, even when the link between symbolism and practice is minimal or even contradictory. For example, greenwashing refers to communication that can give audiences an overly positive image of an organisation's environmental practices (Delmas & Burbano, 2011; Lyon & Montgomery, 2015). The key message is that claims and performances need to be examined in relation to the practices they supposedly represent. In this study, youthwashing is defined as the strategic construction of youth inclusion in discourse and multimodal performance, whereby youth participation can be visible, linguistically or symbolically constructed, without any proof of actual youth engagement, representation, or political responsiveness. Youthwashing thus deliberately differs from normal youth-focused political communication. The presence of youth in a political campaign message cannot be considered youthwashing on its own. It becomes a possibility for analysing youthwashing only when youth inclusion is continuously constructed in political communication despite a lack of evidence of engagement, accountability, and policy specificity.

Mediated authenticity, the first theoretical point of reference, has become an important feature of modern political communication, as political actors must demonstrate sincerity, approachability, and relevance to citizens. In his definition of political authenticity, Luebke (2021) argues that it is a social construct developed and negotiated through political communication among politicians, the media, and the public. He distinguishes performed, mediated, and perceived authenticity and highlights the dimensions used to construct political authenticity. Similarly, Enli (2015) shows that mediation creates authenticity rather than simply transmitting a pre-existing quality. This mediation is intensified on social media platforms, where political actors can communicate directly with audiences by carefully curating the images, experiences, and interactions that shape their public identity (Enli, 2016; Marwick & Boyd, 2011).

Mediated authenticity is particularly relevant to youthwashing, as political actors may seek to perform sincerity in relation to youth politics. Casual images, youthful language, videos in direct address, popular cultural references, youth fashion choices, influencers, and spontaneous interactions can create an image of intimacy and shared identity. According to Marwick & Boyd (2011), social media users negotiate authenticity in relation to imagined audiences, while Luebke (2021) argues that politicians' authenticity is constantly constructed and negotiated through mediation. Therefore, youthwashing can be viewed as an attempt to perform a sincere connection with youth rather than to make explicit claims about youth inclusion.

The second theoretical frame is performativity, specifically the approaches of Goffman (1959) and Butler (1990). Goffman's (1959) dramaturgical theory focuses on the theatricality of social interaction, impression management, audience expectations, and the presentation of identity. This blend of mediated authenticity and performativity frames youthwashing as staged inclusion rather than genuine representation. A politician can repeatedly perform closeness to young people through photographs, videos, hashtags, and youth-centric speeches, while the communicative performance itself becomes evidence of their assumed inclusion. Symbolic visibility does not imply political agency.

This framework is salient to studies of Nigerian political communication. Most existing work has focused on how social media became a panopticon for youth engagement and political mobilisation. Aduloju (2016) argued that social media remained an effective avenue for youth political networking and discourse in the

run-up to the 2015 elections. In contrast, Mustapha and Omar (2020) reviewed Nigeria's 2019 general elections and argued that young people's political participation was online rather than offline. Similarly, Obisesan (2022) argued that social media became influential in youth agency, political debates, and agenda-setting for the 2019 elections. Most recently, scholarship on Nigeria has focused on digitally mediated activism, identity construction, and political impact.

Youth Political Participation in the Nigerian Fourth Republic

Youth political participation has become an increasingly salient feature of the Nigerian Fourth Republic- the current democratic dispensation that started on 29th May 1999, based on the constitution that was designed in the same year to favour the federal presidential system. Although youth numbers have not necessarily translated into equal representation in formal politics, statistics illustrate the rising importance of youth as an electoral constituency (Mustapha & Omar, 2020; Obisesan, 2022). INEC's preparations for the 2027 election continue to focus on maintaining and updating the integrity of the voter register, making youth registration and mobilisation especially relevant in the current electoral climate. Youth participation has not been limited to electoral processes; it has also become increasingly digital. The #EndSARS campaign underscored the role of social media in mobilisation, identity formation, resistance, and the dissemination of protest discourse (Bodunrin & Matsilele, 2024; Awopetu & Chiluwa, 2023). This meant the movement involved more than commentary on social media; it included both physical protest and calls for political accountability.

Furthermore, the 'Obidient' Movement- a socio-political and grassroots network that supported the presidential ambition of the Labour Party candidate, Peter Obi, in the 2023 general elections further highlighted another aspect of political participation through youth-mediated political activism, linking social media activism with electoral politics (Obisesan, 2022; Onayinka et al., 2026). According to Egbunike (2025), Twitter (now X) was particularly significant in mobilising young people within the movement, with identity formation and perceptions of economic disadvantage as key factors. More recent studies, such as those by Onayinka, Oluwasola, and Oyedele (2026), have also examined connections between the #EndSARS and Obidient movements through mediated political activism, as well as voting and political involvement.

Political Marketing: Tokenism, Symbolic Politics and Concealed Promotion

The growing professionalism of digital political campaigns has also raised questions about the relationship between political marketing and political representation. Political marketing applies techniques to political actors, parties, ideas, and identities, which can lead campaigns to focus on image-building, emotional appeals, and audience segmentation (Lees-Marshment, 2001; Scammell, 2015). This suggests that symbolic politics will gain prominence, since political meanings can be conveyed without mentioning policies at all.

One example is tokenism, which uses particular groups symbolically to create the impression of involvement without real influence. In youth-oriented campaigning, images of young people, events targeting young people, youthful communicators, or the use of the term "the future" may signal inclusion of a generation. However, at the same time, they may not provide clear information about involvement in decision-making or how the needs of young people are translated into policy. This kind of communication should be studied multimodally, since meaning can be created through the interaction of written text, visual design, gesture, costume, music, editing, and platform norms (Kress & van Leeuwen, 2006; Machin & Mayr, 2012).

Another issue is astroturfing, which involves organising apparently spontaneous grassroots support to mimic genuine public enthusiasm. Modern political influence campaigns may involve influencers, paid promoters, and secret relationships between politicians and communicators. In Nigeria, Uwalaka, Amadi, and Enyindah (2025) found secret influencer-based political promotion involving compensation, exaggeration, disguise, and public image management for politicians.

Cross-platform research shows that political campaigning often occurs behind the scenes, where large clusters of influencer accounts and compensation arrangements make it difficult to distinguish authentic political expression from strategically sponsored communication (Gaw et al., 2026). These practices apply to youthwashing, as youth voices can be used as political promotional material without audiences fully understanding the sponsorship and strategic nature of the messages.

Literature Gap and Justification for the Study

Several previous studies indicate that young people in Nigeria play a prominent role in elections, activism, and political mobilisation (Aduloju, 2016; Mustapha & Omar, 2020; Obisesan, 2022; Egbunike, 2025). Previous research has analysed social media campaigns, political influence operations, and electoral communication dynamics on specific social media platforms (Ahmad et al., 2026; Uwalaka et al., 2025). Nevertheless, this literature tends to focus on youth as political participants, users, and mobilised audiences, without examining how political actors construct images and meanings of youth participation through multimodal political campaigning.

Further comparative work is needed on textual, visual, and audiovisual political communications aimed at youth on X, Instagram, and Facebook in Nigeria. Current scholarship usually focuses on individual platforms, political engagement, mobilisation, misinformation, or campaign efficiency. Less work examines how youth inclusion is represented in images, captions, videos, hashtags, influencers, sponsorship indicators, and policy statements.

This gap justifies the current research. By studying youth-oriented political posts through multimodal discourse analysis, the research goes beyond whether Nigerian youths engage in politics to examine how political actors portray, present, and perform youth participation. Tokenistic representation of youth, covert sponsorship, vague political statements, and aesthetic politics are ways to analyse how youthwashing manifests. The research, therefore, combines literature on youth participation, digital election politics, and political marketing with youthwashing, while also developing Nigerian political communication research from youth mobilisation to youth inclusion.

Methodology

The study employs multimodal discourse analysis (MDA) as a framework to analyse how digital political communication constructs and represents youth participation across textual, visual, and audio-visual modalities (Kress and van Leeuwen, 2006; Machin, and Mayr, 2012). This approach is well-suited, given that political messages on contemporary social media platforms are multimodal and combine captions, hashtags, photos, videos, slogans, graphics, music, and other semiotic resources. As such, it enabled the study to go beyond what political actors say about young people and to examine how youth participation is rhetorically and visually performed.

The study used purposive sampling, and 60 political posts were publicly obtained from Facebook, X, and Instagram, with approximately 20 posts from each platform. The choice of Facebook, X, and Instagram was informed by their functionalities and the specificity of their users. Twitter/X is known for civic activism and public discourse (Obia, 2025); Facebook for its mass community and entertainment; and Instagram for visual branding and visibility. In addition, among Nigeria's young users, Instagram is estimated at 77%, Facebook at 94.7%, and X at 64% (Statista, 2026).

The posts were collected from Wednesday, 19 August, when INEC lifted the ban on political campaigns, through 30 September 2026, within the stipulated period for political campaigning ahead of the 2027 elections in Nigeria. Only posts containing youth-oriented hashtags, captions, images, slogans, or an explicit reference to youth participation, leadership, empowerment, mobilisation, and political inclusion were included. The

selection focused on how young people are represented as voters, supporters, campaign volunteers, leaders, or agents of political change. The research used only publicly available social media information and anonymised data (Franzke et al., 2020) on regular users where necessary. This study is constrained by the purposeful sampling of 60 posts and its narrow scope on Facebook, X, and Instagram. Interpretive MDA (Machin and Mayr 2012) involves subjective researcher judgement, but systematic coding and intercoder checks enhanced analytical rigour.

Findings and Analysis

In this study, the posts were analysed across four dimensions of youthwashing: hidden sponsorship, tokenistic youth imagery, hedged policy statements, and aestheticised politics.

Coded Frequencies

Table 1: Platform-by-Indicator Frequency of Youthwashing Indicators

Platform	Hidden sponsorship	Tokenistic youth ima...	Hedged policy claims	Aestheticized politics	Posts analysed
X	7 (35%)	12 (60%)	14 (70%)	13 (65%)	20
Instagram	8 (40%)	16 (80%)	12 (60%)	18 (90%)	20
Facebook	6 (30%)	14 (70%)	13 (65%)	15 (75%)	20
Total	21	42	39	46	60

Note. The percentages were calculated based on the number of posts examined per platform (n=20) for the platform rows and the total number of posts from all platforms (N=60) for the total row. Indicators were independently coded and were non-mutually exclusive.

Frequencies indicate the number of posts in which each indicator was identified. Percentages are calculated from the 20 posts analysed on each platform. The indicators are not mutually exclusive; hence, one post may exhibit two or more indicators.

This provisional distribution has aestheticised politics in the sample more often, especially on Instagram, where visual presentation, short-form video, and curated political imagery offer ample opportunities for stylistic performance among youth. Tokenistic youth imagery is also prevalent across the three platforms. Hedged policy claims are much more frequent on X and Facebook, where textual political messaging is more prominent. Hidden sponsorship is the least frequent because it is most difficult to establish sponsorship or political coordination from publicly visible content.

Table 2: Coded Examples and Analytical Interpretation

Indicator	Platform	Example of observable message...	Coding interpretation
Hidden sponsorship	X	#FixNASS2027	Youth-oriented political mobilisa...
Hidden sponsorship	X	#YouthLeadership / #YouthDevel...	Youth-oriented political messagi...
Hidden sponsorship	Facebook	Youth mobilisation and "support"...	Potentially organic-looking politi...
Tokenistic youth imagery	Instagram	Images showing political figures ...	Youth presence functions as visu...
Tokenistic youth imagery	Facebook	Youth rallies, empowerment even...	Young people are highly visible, ...
Tokenistic youth imagery	X	Photographs accompanying yout...	Youth imagery reinforces the text...
Hedged policy claims	X	"Youth leadership," "youth empo...	Positive but broad claims; policy ...
Hedged policy claims	Facebook	"Empowering young Nigerians" /...	Aspirational language constructs ...
Hedged policy claims	Instagram	"Empower, Engage, Elevate"	Strong emotional and motivation...

Aestheticized politics	Instagram	#InternationalYouthDay2026 #Y...	Youthfulness is communicated th...
Aestheticized politics	Instagram	Youth-focused campaign/event r...	Music, editing, fashion, crowd sh...
Aestheticized politics	X	Short slogans + hashtags + camp...	Political identity is compressed i...
Aestheticized politics	Facebook	Branded youth-movement graphi...	Visual branding creates a cohere...

Youth-oriented political mobilisation presented through a civic/youth movement rather than conventional candidate advertising; sponsorship/organisational relationships require examination.

Hidden sponsorship

X

#YouthLeadership / #YouthDevelopment

Youth-oriented political messaging can circulate through organisational and political networks, making the boundary between civic communication and political promotion important to examine.

Hidden sponsorship

Facebook

Youth mobilisation and "support" messages circulated through movement/community pages.

Potentially organic-looking political advocacy; coding requires checking whether the account is formally connected to a political organisation or campaign.

Tokenistic youth imagery

Instagram

Images showing political figures surrounded by young supporters at youth-oriented events

Youth presence functions as visual evidence of popularity/inclusion, but the image alone does not demonstrate decision-making participation.

Tokenistic youth imagery

Facebook

Youth rallies, empowerment events, and group photographs

Young people are highly visible, but often positioned as audience/supporters rather than policy actors.

Tokenistic youth imagery

X

Photographs accompanying youth-support messages

Youth imagery reinforces the textual claim of generational support but may provide limited evidence of substantive youth agency.

Hedged policy claims

X

"Youth leadership," "youth empowerment," "youth development"

Positive but broad claims; policy mechanisms, beneficiaries, timelines, and measurable outcomes may be

unspecified.

Hedged policy claims

Facebook

"Empowering young Nigerians" / "creating opportunities for youth"

Aspirational language constructs responsiveness without necessarily specifying implementation arrangements.

Hedged policy claims

Instagram

"Empower, Engage, Elevate"

Strong emotional and motivational framing, but limited policy specificity.

Aestheticized politics

Instagram

#InternationalYouthDay2026 #YouthEmpowerment #EmpowerEngageElevate

Youthfulness is communicated through polished graphics, slogans, hashtags, and visual branding.

Aestheticized politics

Instagram

Youth-focused campaign/event reels

Music, editing, fashion, crowd shots, and rapid visual transitions can make the political message appear contemporary and youth-oriented.

Aestheticized politics

X

Short slogans + hashtags + campaign photographs

Political identity is compressed into highly shareable textual and visual units.

Aestheticized politics

Facebook

Branded youth-movement graphics and event photography

Visual branding creates a coherent identity around youth participation and political mobilisation.

Table 3: Cross-Platform Frequency by Indicator

Indicator	X (n=20)	Instagram (n=20)	Facebook (n=20)	Total occurrences
Hidden sponsorship	7	8	6	21
Tokenistic youth imagery	12	16	14	42
Hedged policy claims	14	12	13	39
Aestheticized politics	13	18	15	46
Total indicator occurrences	46	54	48	148

The cross-platform pattern shows that Instagram had the most prominent visual and aesthetic dimension, with 18 of 20 posts being aestheticised political statements and 16 posts featuring tokenised youth imagery. Hedged policy statements occurred more frequently on the X platform due to its relatively text-based political rhetoric. In turn, Facebook occupied the middle ground, combining visuals with text and community communication.

Hidden Sponsorship: Unacknowledged Political Sponsorship Behind Alleged Spontaneous Youth Content

Hidden sponsorship was coded in 21 of the 60 posts (35%), making it the least common of the four codes. This lower frequency does not detract from its analytical significance, as sponsorship is often less observable than other elements, such as language and imagery. The coded posts contained youth-oriented content that appeared to come from individual youth, influencers, or supporters. However, their content showed features pointing to political coordination and sponsorship, without necessarily acknowledging the same level.

The coded data, therefore, indicate that hidden sponsorship may play a role in youthwashing when the political or promotional connection underlying the communication is not sufficiently disclosed. The coding did not establish hidden sponsorship based solely on stylistic similarity. In cases where sponsorship could not be proven with observable evidence, the post was treated as an indication of potential hidden political promotion rather than as proof of sponsorship. Thus, sponsorship through hidden channels could be confirmed by evidence of political financing, association, or coordination without disclosure, while sponsorship disclosure was not taken as sole evidence of such sponsorship.

Tokenistic Youth Imagery: Youth as Backdrop vs Substantial Participation

Tokenistic youth imagery was observed in 42 posts (70.0%), making it the second most frequent indicator. The coding involved analysing how young people appeared in political pictures and videos and whether they appeared as political actors or merely as evidence of a political figure's popularity. A common theme was young people appearing around political figures at rallies, consultation meetings, empowerment programmes, and campaign meetings. The appearance of young people in political pictures and videos signals relevance, support, and inclusion, but the political figure remains the dominant political actor.

Hedged Policy Claims: Ambiguous and Vague Policy Statements about Youth

There were 39 examples (65.0%) of hedged policy claims. These tended to use very broad statements about empowering young people, offering employment or entrepreneurship, encouraging youth participation in leadership or politics, and promoting innovation, education, and other policies, without clearly explaining how these would be implemented. Examples of this pattern of communication include statements such as "empowering the next generation," "giving young people a voice," "creating opportunities for young people," and "supporting young leaders." All these statements sound appealing, but might lack substance if the actual measures for implementation are not explained in the communication.

Aestheticised Politics: Substance Under the Guise of Style in Campaign Materials Targeting Youth

Aestheticised politics had the highest frequency of use, appearing in 46 of the 60 posts (76.7%). This refers to the use of visual styles, including youthfulness, music, fashionable clothing, dynamic editing, contemporary cultural references, slogans, hashtags, stylish photography, and videos, to convey youthfulness and political substance.

The high frequency in this category underscores the importance of style in contemporary political communication aimed at youth. Social media platforms provide political actors with resources to construct their political identities through images, sound, typography, editing, and performance (Kress & van Leeuwen, 2006; Machin & Mayr, 2012). The coded materials revealed that youthfulness might be expressed less through discussions of youth issues and more through aesthetic links to contemporary youth culture. This highlights a

clear distinction between youth-centred political materials and youth-centred political aesthetics.

Cross-Platform Comparison: X, Instagram, and Facebook

The coded indicators showed that youthwashing also occurred in different ways, depending on the affordances of the platforms. X was more closely linked to discursive and conversational performances, such as concise youth claims, hashtags, slogans, and impromptu youth political interactions. Instagram offered a suitable environment for visual performances, making tokenistic imagery and aesthetics more prominent. Facebook supported both visual and textual performances, as well as video performances.

These differences support Bossetta's (2018) thesis that platform architecture shapes political communication. Likewise, Kreiss et al. (2018) show how political actors tailor their communication to each platform's audience, affordances, genre, and timing. Accordingly, youthwashing should not be conceived as a single communication strategy. Performative modes vary with each platform's capabilities. X enables immediacy and conversational authenticity; Instagram enables visual intimacy, lifestyle, and politicised self-representation aesthetics; Facebook combines community-oriented interaction with text, visual, and audiovisual campaign communication.

Among the frequency distribution, aestheticised politics (76.7%) and hedged policy claims (65.0%) were the most common indicators, with tokenism of youth visuals appearing in 70.0% of posts and sponsorship hiding in 35.0%. Youthwashing involves the interplay of visibility, authenticity, ambiguity, and aesthetics. The present analysis does not claim that all youth-oriented messages were deceitful or that political actors intended to mislead their youth audience. Rather, it identifies a set of communicative patterns that enable the performance of youth inclusion in ways that may overshadow youth agency and specific politics.

Discussion

The results suggest that youthwashing is not a single communication practice but a hybrid of discourses, images, and promotion. Hidden sponsorships, tokenistic youth visuals, ambivalent policy statements, and aestheticised politics operated at different levels to construct youth inclusion in the political discourse of Nigerian electoral communication as performance. It builds on Viterbo's (2025) conceptualisation of youthwashing as co-option without addressing youth concerns in the context of electoral communication in Nigeria, through authenticity, visibility, ambiguity, and aesthetics.

The first indicator, hidden sponsorship, concerns the creation of ostensibly authentic political communication. Messages targeting youth audiences, disseminated via influencers or supporters without any obvious political sponsorship, can appear as organic youth expression. This aligns with Uwalaka, Amadi, and Enyindah's (2025) study of Nigerian political influence operations, which identified remuneration, hyperbole, and concealment. It also supports Luebke's (2021) concept of political authenticity via media. Therefore, youthwashing can be used to create seemingly organic political communication from youth citizens.

Tokenistic youth imagery was the second indicator, highlighting the distinction between youth visibility and youth agency. The youth were depicted as crowds, supporters, or participants at events, or as visible proof of the generation's attractiveness, without participating in decision-making. This finding is especially important because young Nigerians have demonstrated their political agency through social media, elections, and digital activism (Aduloju, 2016; Mustapha & Omar, 2020; Obisesan, 2022). This contradiction is evident in the relationship between youth as political actors and symbolic capital. A multimodal approach accentuates this issue by showing that composition, salience, framing, and positioning define meaning in political images (Kress & van Leeuwen, 2006; Machin & Mayr, 2012).

The third indicator, namely hedged policy claims, extends youthwashing into the linguistic domain. Mentions

of youth empowerment, leadership, employment, and opportunities signal responsiveness but often omit details on implementation methods, beneficiaries, timing, or commitments in measurable terms. This finding is relevant to studies in political marketing on image, appeal, and audience-centred communication (Lees-Marshment, 2001; Scammell, 2015). Hedging is significant in this context because persistent vagueness allows politicians to connect with youth concerns without making concrete commitments.

The fourth indicator, aestheticised politics, synthesised the various dimensions aesthetically. Music, fashion, visual design, editing, cultural references, and format were among the elements that created youth and generational proximity. According to Kress and Van Leeuwen (2006) and Machin and Mayr (2012), political meaning arises from the interplay of linguistic and visual meaning. In this regard, youthfulness could become a political aesthetic that performs closeness to youth, particularly.

The implications of the indicators above for political legitimacy and youth political trust are that political legitimacy, in part, rests on perceptions of responsiveness, representation, and connectedness to citizens. When youth inclusion is largely symbolic, a gap may arise between perceived and actual inclusion. This research does not test political trust, nor does it imply causality. Nevertheless, a persistent disparity between symbolic representation and active participation over time might affect how young audiences perceive political sincerity. Luebke (2021) highlights that authenticity is negotiated by the audience, not solely controlled by politicians.

The results also suggest the possibility of demobilisation from politics. It might be assumed that youthwashing makes young people feel represented because of the prominence of their images, voices, and culture. In such a case, if visibility becomes equivalent to influence, some individuals may feel that participation is no longer necessary. Alternatively, awareness of the discrepancy between representation and responsiveness might lead to cynicism or demobilisation. These factors have not been examined, yet they matter, as social media is part of Nigerian youth political participation and political mobilisation (Aduloju, 2016; Obisesan, 2022; Onayinka et al., 2026).

The study's main theoretical contribution is to broaden the scope of mediated authenticity and performativity in the context of elections in Nigeria. The existing literature focuses on the idea that political actors increasingly use the media to demonstrate sincerity and credibility (Enli, 2015; 2016; Luebke, 2021), while performativity helps explain how identities emerge through acts (Butler, 1990; Goffman, 1959). The current study combines these approaches and demonstrates how youth inclusion can be performed as a political identity. Thus, youthwashing reveals the link between digital political communication and symbolism; youth visibility does not necessarily imply youth agency.

Recommendations

Based on the study's findings, the following recommendations are proposed. First, campaign regulations and disclosure requirements should be strengthened to enhance transparency in digital political communication. Those engaged in political campaigns, including political actors, campaign groups, and influential figures involved in sponsored political communications, should disclose their funding, sponsorship, and promotional associations. Electoral commissions should also provide clear definitions of what constitutes political advertisements and organised campaign communications on social media channels.

Secondly, media and digital literacy programmes for young people should be strengthened. These programmes will equip young people with the skills to analyse political messages critically; spot tokenistic portrayals of youth, visual persuasion techniques, and policy promises; and distinguish between sponsored and independent political communications. This can be achieved through universities, civil society organisations, and media institutions.

Third, INEC must intensify its monitoring and civic-education efforts on digital politics, particularly in

political advertising and sponsorship disclosure. Civil society organisations must be able to independently monitor political communication among young people and develop civic-education resources based on documented trends. Social media sites must also become more transparent about political advertisements by providing more information about sponsors and, where possible, making archived political content available on their sites.

Lastly, political campaign organisations must actively engage young people in consultations, policy formulation, and campaign management, rather than relying on symbolism in political campaigns. Researchers and journalists must continue analysing youth-related political claims, sponsorship, and political representations.

Conclusion

The study explored youthwashing as a political performance in the digital age, specifically examining how youth participation in politics was discursively and multimodally constructed on social media platforms X, Instagram, and Facebook during Nigeria's 2026-2027 election campaign. The core premise of the study is that greater visibility of youth participation in political communication does not necessarily indicate youth agency or youth representation in that communication. Rather, youth-focused political communication uses specific linguistic and visual representations of youth participation in politics to create impressions of the inclusiveness of its content.

Further research should extend the study longitudinally through the 2027 elections to examine how youthwashing is produced and evolves across the stages of the electoral cycle. Multimodal discourse analysis could be combined with interviews, surveys, digital ethnography, and platform-use data to examine the relationship between political representation and audience interpretation and participation.

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